Delphi Project Handoff User Guide

Explore an unfamiliar Delphi application

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Open a project, follow its files into screens and actions, and assess what the evidence can show

Experimental software

This manual describes Delphi Project Handoff. Information about a selected Delphi application is presented separately by the program.

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PART 1 Getting started

1 What Delphi Project Handoff does

1.1 Purpose and limits

Delphi Project Handoff, or DPH, prepares an evidence-based handoff for an unfamiliar Delphi application. It reads a selected .dproj, .dpr, or .groupproj and related Pascal units, saved forms, project-local guides, notes, and logs. DPH does not compile, run, or modify the selected application.

Begin with the Handoff dossier. It distinguishes source and document evidence from suggestions about where to read next, then links startup forms, visible commands, data candidates, and unresolved questions to the underlying capture. DPH cannot establish every business rule, permission, runtime state, or outcome. Treat a proposed relationship in an application diagram as a route to investigate, not proof that an action occurred.

1.2 What you need

The 0.8.0.20 experiment offers four clearly labeled ZIP files. Choose one complete Windows edition, Win64 or Win32, to run DPH. The build-ready source ZIP builds both editions without a Windows ZIP. The fourth ZIP contains optional translation-authoring projects for contributors; it is not needed to run or build the app. None is an installer. Extract the chosen ZIP completely. Keep WebView2Loader.dll beside the executable, its Localization/Languages folder in place, and the shared help, migrations, and artwork folders at the extracted root. Microsoft WebView2 Runtime is needed for formatted pages. For a source build, install the supplied DAT design package through RAD Studio 37's Component > Install Packages > Add command, then open DelphiProjectHandoff.dproj and build Win32 or Win64. The project already includes the translation source search path.

The User Guide explains the visible app. The Engineering Guide explains its implementation and validation. DPH's original code and documentation are licensed under Apache 2.0; bundled dependencies have separate terms listed in THIRD_PARTY_NOTICES.md.

2 Open your first project

2.1 The main window

DPH opens on Getting started. It does not reopen the last saved project until you choose one. The header contains Open application, Open saved project, Save project, Rescan project, Close, the Read public websites checkbox, the language selector, and six tabs: Getting started, Handoff dossier, Learning library, Project map, Screenshots, and Application diagrams. Rescan project becomes available when an attached project is ready. Handoff dossier has a formatted HTML introduction before a project is chosen; once a capture loads, it becomes the project's four-part HTML dossier. The status line reports when project preparation is under way or complete. The selected language changes DPH's interface and authored HTML pages offline in all 35 supplied languages. The German choice also offers an experimental local translation of selected English project prose; original files, code identifiers, and citations remain unchanged. A generated form preview can use German captions from the selected project's own Localization/Languages/de-DE.json when supplied; otherwise it shows the saved captions. Project documents and source-derived prose that DPH cannot translate remain in their original language.

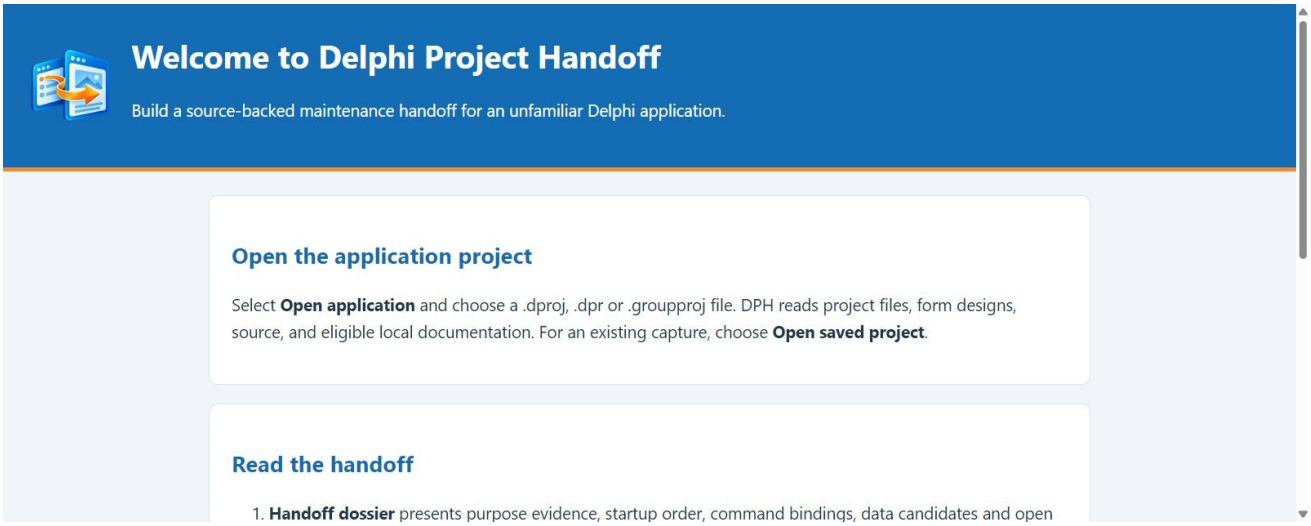


Figure 1. The current Getting started page in DPH, captured from its embedded browser.

2.2 Open the source

1. Click Open application and choose the target application's .dproj, .dpr, or .groupproj file. Do not select DPH's own project.

2. Wait for preparation to finish. A separate centered progress window names the current step, notes that a large project may take a few minutes, and shows a percentage beside the progress bar. Read the progress message, then confirm the project name and capture status in Handoff dossier.

3. Open Screenshots to see whether saved form definitions produced design previews. A tabbed form has a separate preview for each saved tab.

4. Explore the project without saving a permanent database. Click Save project at any time to keep the capture as a .dphdb. The save dialog starts in DPH's databases folder and suggests a dated filename when a previous save has the project's name. A confirmation shows the full saved path. If it is still unsaved when you close DPH or open another project, choose Yes to open that save dialog, No to discard it, or Cancel to keep exploring. Check that the saved .dphdb and its adjacent .dphdb.views folder both exist. If a save fails, DPH displays the error and retains the temporary capture. It never silently replaces a previous save. You may save elsewhere outside the target source folder; keep both saved items together.

If you already have a .dphdb, click Open saved project. Wait until the Handoff dossier itself appears before using the other tabs. DPH restores the captured findings and managed images, then checks any attached source in the background; it does not run the target application. The progress window stays visible until the real dossier page loads. If a previous DPH session stopped during a database write, keep its adjacent SQLite journal in place: DPH recovers it when opening the saved project. Do not separate the .dphdb from its .dphdb.views folder.

When the attached Delphi project changes, click Rescan project in the header. DPH checks the current source and selection, reuses unchanged analysis where valid, and refreshes changed findings. The centered progress window reports the current stage and percentage. If the saved capture is detached from its source, attach the source before rescanning.

2.3 If information is missing

A project may have no helpful guide, no saved form, or code that the analyzer cannot resolve. DPH should show the available evidence and mark uncertain conclusions. A missing document or diagram connection is not evidence that

the target application lacks that behavior. Ask someone familiar with the application when its purpose or operating rules cannot be established from files.

PART 2 Explore the application

3 Read the Handoff dossier

3.1 Follow the evidence

Handoff dossier has four parts. Handoff overview reports capture status, a documented or reviewed purpose when available, startup form registrations, saved form designs, and a suggested reading tour. Commands and workflows lists clickable control events with their connected handlers. Data and operations shows static data and output candidates. Risks and open questions collects author questions and analyzer diagnostics. Each item must be checked against its cited source before being used as an operating instruction.

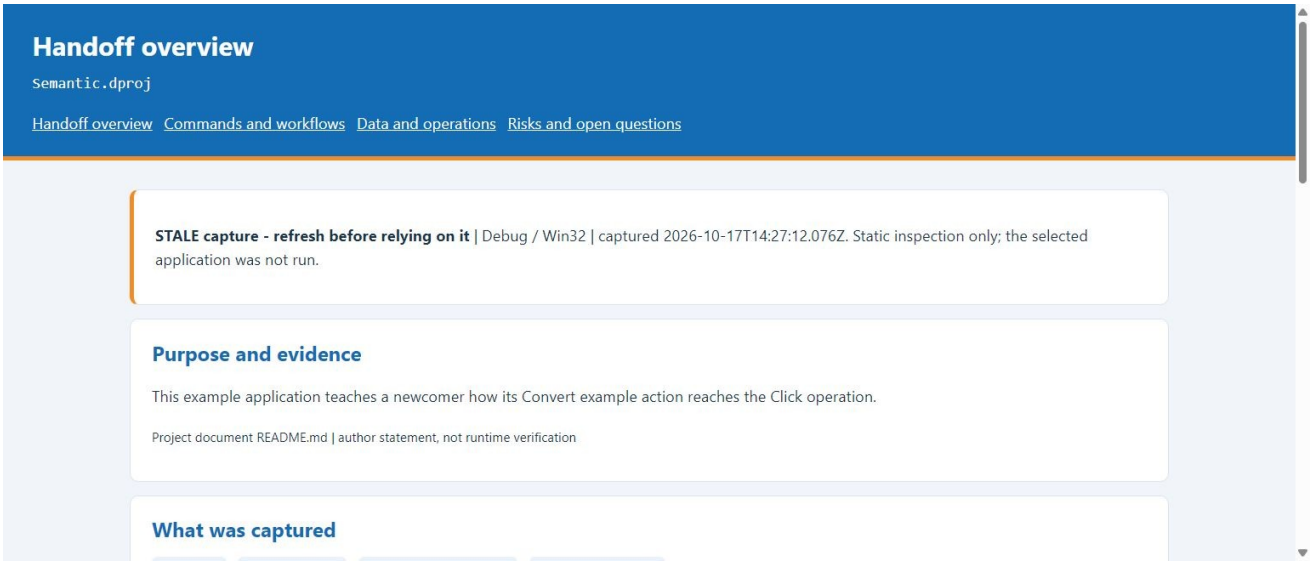


Figure 2. A detached example capture in the Handoff dossier; DPH cannot verify its original source in this test view.

Figure 2 shows a detached example capture. Its timestamp records when DPH read the files; it is not an expiration date. The notice "Project analysis is incomplete" means DPH saved what it found, but some results may be missing. Choose Open Coverage in the notice, select a diagnostic, then choose Inspect selected gap to see the affected source. Correct any missing file, path, or project setting and choose Rescan project. STALE capture means the saved findings need source verification or a fresh analysis. When the original source is available, Open saved project verifies it in the background. It reuses unchanged saved findings instead of repeating the same long scan, and refreshes when source files, analyzer versions, or reading settings change. If source is unavailable, DPH can display the detached saved findings but cannot verify them. Restore an inaccessible file and reopen the project; unsupported constructs and unresolved connections may remain qualified after a fresh scan.

Static inspection only remains after every refresh because DPH never runs the selected application. Startup registration does not prove which window first appeared, and a saved event binding does not prove its handler ran. Use source links and project documents to check the dossier; DPH does not invent a business purpose when none was found.

3.2 Follow a source link

A linked form or control opens the relevant view or selection. Use Back to return to the preceding selection, Up one level to move to a containing object, Save place to remember a location, and Saved places to revisit it. Next results advances when another page of object results is available. These commands navigate findings; they are not steps in the selected application's task.

3.3 Build and data prerequisites

Handoff overview lists captured project directories and relevant .dproj search, include, resource, namespace and output properties with source lines. These values describe the selected build variant; they are not a complete recipe for another computer. Delphi IDE global Library and Browsing paths are machine settings. Ask the maintainer which vendor source or compiled package directories must be added under Tools > Options > Environment Options > Delphi Options > Library, then verify the exact paths on the target computer. Missing units can also result from excluded source roots or conditional compilation.

Open Component dependencies to inspect saved VCL/FMX controls, class declarations and package references. It can point to possible third-party requirements, including products such as TMS, DevExpress or JVCL, but cannot establish vendor, version, license or installation from a class prefix. Record confirmed product details and support contacts in the dependency record.

Data and operations links to Database connections and Database schema. Database connections inventories supported FireDAC, IBX/InterBase, ADO, datasets, data sources and FMX binding references with source qualifications. The dossier includes starting FireDAC templates for InterBase, SQL Server and SQLite; replace every placeholder with approved environment-specific settings outside source control. Confirm the driver unit, client library, server, authentication and database path before attempting a connection. Unit-level variables are listed with source locations; their runtime values and initialization order are not established by a declaration.

4 Read the Learning library

4.1 Topics and documents

The left pane groups starting topics, discovered documents, and screens. Choose an item to read its formatted content in the right pane. A document found in more than one location has a location selector; each location retains its own content and source path. Search the list by title or relevant text when many entries are present.

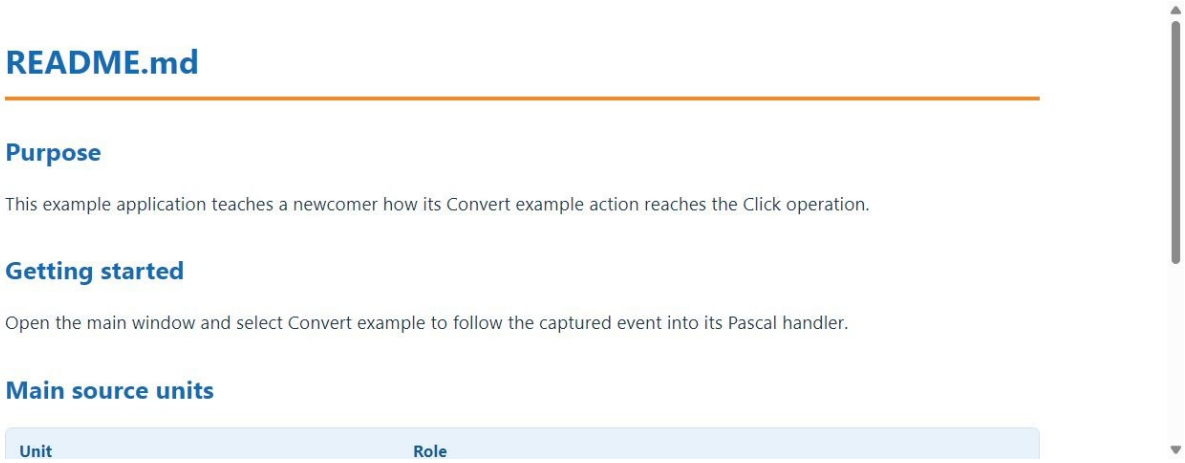


Figure 3. A project README displayed as formatted content in the current Learning library.

Document discovery reads the selected project's root README and named guides, plus documents in its docs, docs/guides, docs/pdf, and docs/notes folders. It excludes unrelated root files such as AGENTS.md and does not descend into separate release packages or archives. When the root README identifies a major version, document names bearing a different explicit version are skipped. PDF, older Word, RTF, and similar formats require LibreOffice at its standard Windows installation path for text extraction. DOCX and supported text formats are read directly. If a file has no usable text, the library says so rather than presenting an empty page. Scanned image-only PDFs may require OCR elsewhere before DPH can read them.

4.2 Language and online references

All 35 interface language packs work offline. German additionally has a bundled experimental English-to-German model for selected project prose in Handoff dossier and Learning library. It runs locally, may make translation mistakes, and does not alter the original files or saved evidence. Other language choices and unmarked project content remain in the source language. DPH-authored memo directions use the installed interface language packs; project-derived prose and technical labels can still appear in their source language. Technical names, code and citations stay as written.

Read public websites starts unchecked. When you enable it, the next analysis may fetch limited text from up to three eligible public HTTPS pages listed in the selected project's sitemap.txt or cited in its documents. Successfully fetched pages appear as Public website entries in the Learning library. DPH does not offer a general web search. Leave the checkbox off for a local-only project read; changing it does not retroactively remove evidence from a saved analysis. Each fetched response is capped at 128 KiB. DPH rejects local-looking hosts and privately resolved IPv4 addresses, pins each request to its checked public address, uses no proxy, and does not follow redirects. If Windows cannot apply address pinning, the request is skipped. This optional feature requires Windows 10 21H1 or later.

5 Inspect source and forms

5.1 Project map

Project map lists captured units, types, objects, controls, procedures, functions, variables, and related items. Filter the left list, expand a unit, and select an item to see its type, declaration, source, and connections. Some relationships are inferred or unresolved; read the explanation and source reference before relying on them.

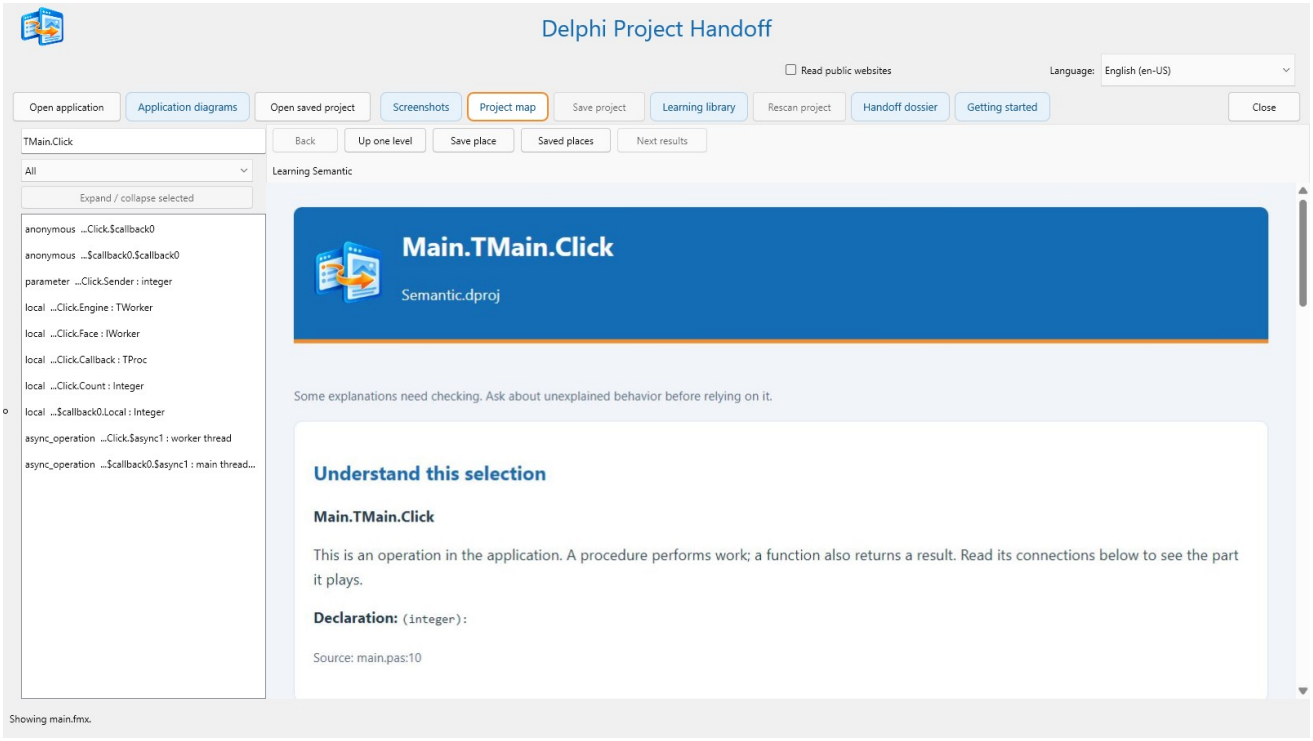


Figure 4. The current DPH window showing a selected Pascal operation and its source-linked explanation.

5.2 Change Guide

Choose Change Guide from the Project map toolbar to investigate a proposed change before editing code. Its introduction explains how to start. Select a specific control or routine on the left, such as a button's click handler; a whole Pascal unit is usually too broad. The guide shows incoming uses, up to 24 distinct nearby downstream objects across two relationship levels, files worth opening, any contributor guidance linked to the exact object, suggested checks, and unresolved questions. Expand the captured connection evidence and follow its source citations. An inferred link is a clue, not a runtime observation or an instruction to edit.

Use View source code to inspect the selected declaration and Change impact to inspect the existing dependency diagram. Return to guide resumes the guide; Return to map restores the ordinary Project map explanation. The toolbar scrolls horizontally when a narrow window or translated button labels need more width. The generated Change Guide narrative is an English-language beta in this release. Its new native navigation buttons are available through the 35 offline language packs. DPH does not change or run the selected project, choose an implementation, or mark tests as passed. The separate Change_Guide.txt has a focused walkthrough and feedback guidance.

5.3 Screenshots

Screenshots creates a design preview for each distinct supported .fmx or .dfm form definition when you open the page. A form with saved tabs receives a main-screen preview with its initial tab and a separate preview for each saved tab. DPH saves these views beside the .dphdb. Previews open at 90 percent zoom; choose Native pixels for full-size text, Fit for a whole-form overview, or Custom zoom for another size. Scroll to see portions outside the viewport. These are design-time reconstructions, not photographs of the target application running. Custom painting, styles, data, and runtime layout may differ. You may import an actual PNG captured from the running application as separately attributed evidence.

5.4 Application diagrams

Application diagrams show possible form navigation, routine calls, information paths, or dependencies found in project files. Choose a diagram type and read its explanation above the drawing. Select a box to inspect the represented object. Blue solid arrows are direct file connections; orange dashed arrows need interpretation. A limited drawing may omit nodes or arrows, so use a focused selection or another grouping when the larger diagram is crowded.

PART 3 Continue safely

6 Reopen and troubleshoot

6.1 Reopen a saved project

Keep the .dphdb and adjacent .dphdb.views folder together. Click Open saved project and select the database. Confirm the project name, library topics, and generated screens. If source files have moved or changed, an old capture may be incomplete; verify links against the current source before treating them as current.

6.2 Common problems

If Handoff dossier says STALE capture, follow the verification steps in section 3.1. Open saved project checks available attached source in the background. It rescans when inputs, analyzer versions, or reading settings changed, but an unchanged incomplete analysis stays qualified until missing source becomes available or analysis improves. Open application selects the source entry again. The phrase Static inspection only always remains because DPH never runs the selected application. If formatted pages are blank, check that Microsoft WebView2 Runtime is installed and WebView2Loader.dll is beside the DPH executable. If a PDF or older word-processing file has no text, install LibreOffice in its standard Windows location and reopen the application project. If a form view is approximate, inspect the actual .fmx or .dfm and remember that runtime painting is outside this generator's evidence.

If a project takes longer than expected, watch the preparation message for the current stage. Large source trees, office-document conversion, and referenced HTTPS sites can add time. DPH limits the document scan and does not require Internet access to open the project.

6.3 Share a read-only handoff

Open Sharing and choose Export handoff. Select a new destination folder; DPH will not overwrite an existing edition. Click Preview handoff to inspect its opening page. The portable edition starts with handoff-0.html and has four linked dossier pages, a technical index, source-linked object explanations, and the earlier learning edition at learning.html. Share the whole folder, not an individual HTML page, after reviewing its scope, source citations, author claims, images, and any sensitive material. Validation hashes detect changes relative to the captured manifest; they do not authenticate the author.

7 First use acceptance checklist

7.1 A practical review

1. Open a small Delphi project that is not DPH and verify that the dossier names the project and cites its startup form.

2. Follow one control from its screen to its source declaration or handler, then use Back to return.

3. Open Change Guide for that control or handler. Inspect an incoming connection, a nearby source link, the file list, and a suggested check. Return from source or the impact diagram to the same guide; remember that the generated guide narrative is an English-language beta.

4. Read a project guide in Learning library. Confirm that its text is readable and its file location is identifiable.

5. Open a generated blank screen and compare its saved controls with the form definition.

6. Open an application diagram and verify that a selected box opens the expected object.

7. Close and reopen the .dphdb with its .views folder; confirm that the same project and screens appear.

8. Switch DPH to another interface language and back. Confirm that the project's original text does not change.